

James J.G Bias and Eliza Bias: Medical Care and Social Support for Freedom Seekers in 1838

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Published: Nov 4, 2023

Main Article

When historical narratives disappear, they often leave traces that point toward larger, untold stories. Dr. James Joshua Gould Bias represents one such figure—appearing repeatedly across historical documents yet lacking mainstream recognition or biographical entries.

The author first encountered Dr. Bias in the 1838 Register of Trades of the Colored People of Philadelphia, part of a coordinated effort by Black leadership and the Pennsylvania Abolition Society to prevent voting disenfranchisement. This campaign produced four key documents: a census, a trades register, statistical reports, and a political appeal.

Dr. Bias and his wife Eliza lived at 2 Acorn Alley in 1838. The author discovered that the Vigilance Committee of Philadelphia—the original organizational leadership of the Underground Railroad—met at their home. The alley now forms part of the Penn Hospital complex, located between Spruce and Locust streets.

The Vigilant Committee, established to aid "colored persons in distress," provided immediate post-emancipation support for freedom seekers. Dr. Bias served as a leader in the 1837 iteration. Committee records reveal multiple references to cases "reported by J.J.G. Bias," suggesting community members knew to seek his assistance. One July 1838 entry notes a woman from Virginia "Reported by J.J.G. Bias" with expenses of \$3.00; another December case shows similar patterns.

According to *Scraps of African Methodist Episcopal History*, Dr. Bias was born enslaved in Maryland but worked as a carriage driver to a physician. After gaining freedom, he moved to Philadelphia. He initially worked as a whitewasher (someone who plastered brick buildings), then transitioned to medical practice, providing services like "leeching, bleeding, and extracting decayed teeth." His wife Eliza practiced as a "cupper"—a medical treatment provider.

The higher expense noted in one Vigilance Committee case (\$9.50 versus typical \$2-3 costs) suggests medical attention was involved. Dr. Bias and Eliza advertised their services in newspapers, making their address at 2 Acorn Alley strategically visible to potential patients and freedom seekers alike. The address appeared in every issue of the *Colored American* in 1840, when Dr. Bias served as an agent for the publication.

In 1841, the Bias family moved to 8th and Bedford, placing them in the center of violent mob attacks occurring 1841-1842. A November 1848 *Liberator* article noted that "Dr. Bias has thrown his whole soul into the work, and his labors have been second to none," while also indicating that "in some instances their property was burnt, and otherwise destroyed."

A notable incident involved Harriet Bayley, a freedom seeker assisted by the Vigilant Committee. According to *The Kidnapped and the Ransomed*, Peter Still (brother of William Still) stayed with the Bias family upon arriving in Philadelphia, and Eliza encouraged him to visit the Pennsylvania Anti-Slavery Society office, where he reunited with his brother.

The Bias family subsequently moved to 157 South 6th Street (1843), then 189 South 6th Street (1851), and finally 606 Pine Street (between 1855-1860). Notably, dentist Joseph Brister—father of James Brister, the first Black graduate of the University of Pennsylvania—also practiced at 606 Pine, suggesting a possible Black-owned medical clinic existed there a decade before Douglas and Mercy hospitals were established.

The 1860 Census lists Dr. Bias as age 50 and Eliza as 36, with a one-year-old child named Leonard Bias also in the household, though no additional records of this child have been located.

Dr. Bias attended to George Williams in January 1852, a freedom seeker involved in the Christiana incident. Williams had escaped capture and walked from Lancaster to Philadelphia, where Dr. Bias "nursed and attended" him. *The Freedman's Story* described Dr. Bias as "one of the faithful few, whose labors for the oppressed will never be forgotten."

Beyond these activities, Dr. Bias also preached at Mother Bethel, authored a book on phrenology, helped establish the Carthaginian Lodge of the Oddfellows, and graduated from the Eclectic Medical College in 1852, finally obtaining formal credentials for work he had practiced for years.

The author theorizes that the Vigilant Committee disseminated Dr. Bias's address as a known safe haven for freedom seekers. His involvement across multiple institutions—churches, anti-slavery organizations, medical networks, fraternal societies—made him a central figure in the community, even if not historically documented as such.

This story suggests several critical points often absent from standard histories:

- Advanced social and community organization skills within the Black community

- Strategic use of public media for veiled communications
- Positioning of community leaders as signals to freedom seekers
- A more extensive and Black-led Underground Railroad safehouse network operating within Philadelphia
- The loss of crucial community heroes from historical memory

Images

- How we envision James and Eliza Bias — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_6690976844e141ae9daea3813830e216~mv2.png
- Appeal of forty thousand citizens document image — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_93119253065d43dd9ae21feab1d8bc32~mv2.png
- 1838 Register excerpt — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_2a3640cd7e664146aa0d335a25116aa9~mv2.png
- Vigilance Committee notes reference — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_8ac9d720d2194bcf9b137cc284a09b03~mv2.png
- Colored American newspaper masthead — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_8458acf6623048d39431a2229cceeafe~mv2.png
- 606 Pine Street historical photograph — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_3e2aadd4639f41c8a07501c9ca5a86ee~mv2.png
- Advertisement image — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_10db242b6b034905916a05f0a1b7d12a~mv2.png

WORDCOUNT: 1,280